that their borewells were running dry, a clear indication that groundwater levels were depleting. And people who were dependent on tanker water started reporting an issue with supply." The BBMP also began a registration drive for tankers—to streamline supply and preventing them from focusing on areas where the chances for profiteering were higher. Shivakumar chose to make a point of this on March 9, saying: "For the first time in the history of the state, we have taken on the water mafia by taking over private water tankers." In addition, the authorities are commandeering unused milk tankers to supply water to the drier parts of the expanding metropolis.



DEEPENING CRISIS BJP supporters protest the water shortage, Mar. 12

Yet, the sense of panic refuses to dissipate. Micro and small manufacturing units in the northwestern industrial belt are feeling it. The Peenya Industrial Area is home to some 16,000 manufacturing units—mostly in engineering—that cumulatively employ 1.2 million workers. The worry is about production getting hit without regular water, especially for operations such as cooling down industrial machinery. "There is a scarcity, everybody knows it. What's important is how you are going to handle it," says Arif H.M., president of the Peenya Industries Association.

Authorities are adopting a three-pronged approach. Besides reining in the tanker mafia, the authorities are also turning to tertiary treated water—a source that experts say can potentially offer a long-term solution to Bengaluru's cyclical encounters with drought. Currently, the BWSSB recycles about 1,300 MLD, but this mostly goes back into the stormwater drains. The plan is to set up a portal on which industrial/commercial consumers can requisition treated water via tankers. The more creative—and doable—plan is to use the treated water to recharge groundwater aquifers.

A double whammy was the inordinate delay in **desilting major lakes** in the city to store more water in them

THE LAKES INFERIOR

If the weak 2023 monsoon was the chief cause of this dry spell, the double whammy came from the inordinately long period it has taken for the civic authorities to desilt water bodies in Bengaluru. "There has been no water storage in many of the lakes for a couple of years or more," says water expert S. Vishwanath. For instance, the two largest water bodies in Bengaluru—at Bellandur and Varthur—have not filled up for the past four years, says Vishwanath, who estimates that the aquifer recharge rate of these two lakes would be in the order of 102 MLD. "That would have filled the aquifers over a period of 6-8 months if the lakes were full. In crisis, we could have tapped into it." The plan now is to fast-track this process by filling up lakes with treated water and access this water via filtered borewells, a method that was demonstrated in Devanahalli town, 36 km north of Bengaluru, in 2023.

Vishwanath, whose organisation Biome Environmental Trust conceptualised the project, tells us exactly how the Devanahalli municipal council brought in treated wastewater into the local water body that had been desilted. "The earth was doing a very good job of filtration," he says. "So we took the help of the Indian Institute of Science and designed a basic treatment plant and linked it up to the town's water supply." It's also a cost-effective treatment system, averaging Rs 1.50 per thousand litres, he adds. By replicating this approach in a few lakes across Bengaluru, the BWSSB is hoping to augment its water supply. "With this, we will be able to tap about 10-20 MLD depending on the availability of lake beds in the first phase," says Manohar. "By March 31, we will be able to bring the system into action."

In the longer term, the groundwater-dependent peripheral areas will be connected to piped Cauvery water. The project to supply 775 MLD of Cauvery water to these areas, comprising 110 villages, began in 2020, but was stymied by Covid. By ironing out the bottlenecks such as forest clearances, highway crossings and equipment supplies, the BWSSB is hoping to advance the commissioning date to May from the original deadline of December 2024. "Till then, we need to minimise the impact of depletion via borewells," says Manohar. For the moment, this means an even, buzzing traffic of water tankers. ■